was his justification for staying on the old course, that we were getting on very well on our own. He also told Gorbachev this. That decided matters.24

Although in pain, the SED leader lumbered to his feet that same evening at a gala dinner at the Palace of the Republic to deliver a bulky oration lauding decades of achievements. He described the GDR as a state with modern industry and agriculture, a socialist education system, with flourishing science, culture and world-class athletics. ‘So much is certain for us,’ he said. ‘The slogan coined in the founding period of the GDR still applies: “Forward ever, backward never.”’ Concerning economic achievements, he promised to continue his social policy, wherein residential housing construction was a top priority: ‘At the same time, we will dedicate more attention to the need for consumer goods and services.’25

Though listening with an obliging smile, Gorbachev thought the speech was devoid of anything regarding the present situation, nor contained analysis or conclusions. Schabowski described it as a long and painful recitation of East German successes. When Honecker finally wrapped up, Gorbachev sarcastically enquired, ‘Was that everything?’26

It is hard to explain this failure of judgment, the most critical mistake Honecker ever made. Publicly favouring the status quo over the promise of reforms was a severe lapse, regardless of whether he was committed to delivering changes or not. His logical powers, his early warning system, crashed. Romanian observers noted visible disappointment among the audience with the fact that the First Secretary made no references to possible liberalisation of the socio-political structure.

As this was all going on, several hundred members of the Free German Youth – the organisation Honecker founded four decades earlier – sprang a nasty surprise by chanting, ‘Gorby, help us! Gorby, save us!’ outside the Palace of the Republic. Although prevented from reaching the entrance, the protests spilled over into other areas of the city, especially around some churches, where police intervened. Honecker, later claimed, he had ‘no idea’ about the protests but was convinced ‘not only the dissidents’ were involved: ‘I learned about it only the day after. But that was a very bad